THE CAMPAIGN BLUEPRINT

BJP

- Seek emphatic mandate for PM Narendra Modi and his development agenda
- Capitalise on core Hindutva issues like the Ram temple construction and abrogation of Article 370
- Balance aspirations of Rajputs, Jats, tribals and other key communities in ticket allocation
- Highlight the new BJP regime's action in paper leak and illegal mining cases that surfaced during the previous Congress government

CONGRESS

- Not spread itself too thin and concentrate on seats where the party can give a close fight to the BJP
- Put up a united fight along with the three allies—BAP, RLP and CPI(M)—who have got a seat each
- Corner the Modi regime over the now-scrapped electoral bond scheme and alleged misuse of the Enforcement Directorate
- Remind the voters of welfare schemes launched by the previous Gehlot regime

that, the Jats too need to be kept in good humour. In Ajmer, the BJP has retained sitting MP and Jat leader Bhagirath Chaudhary, despite his recent assembly poll defeat. In Jhunjhunu, Shubhkaran Chaudhary, another casualty of the 2023 polls, has been granted a second chance. In Nagaur, the party has placed its faith in Jyoti Mirdha, granddaughter of Jat icon Nathu Ram and former Congress MP whose last electoral win came in 2009. However, the BJP's faith in her underscores its lack of alternatives in certain seats as much as its pragmatism. This, even as the party has been bold enough to continue circumscribing the turf of former CM Vasundhara Raje (who's mostly reduced to campaigning for son Dushyant Singh in Jhalawar-Baran) and deny tickets to 11 of its sitting MPs.

While the BJP plays with calculated risk, the Congress seems to be moving from blunder to blunder. In Jaipur, its original candidate Sunil Sharma was forced into a red-faced withdrawal after a huge protest over his association with the right-wing digital platform Jaipur Dialogues. The party's next choice, former minister Pratap Singh Khachariawas, openly admitted his reluctance to contest, still reeling from his assembly election defeat. In Jhunjhunu, too, sitting MLA Brijendra Singh Ola confessed to his lack of enthusiasm for the upcoming electoral battle. In Rajsamand, Sudarshan Singh Rawat returned his ticket, claiming he had never consented to the nomination. Forced into a frantic reshuffle, the Congress shifted Damodar Gurjar from Bhilwara to Rajsamand, and drafted former speaker C.P. Joshi to contest from Bhilwara despite his assembly poll debacle.

But the real comedy of errors unfolded in the tribal belt—comic only for onlookers, of course, and fairly tragic for the party—where a last-minute clinching of an alliance with the Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP) left two Congress candidates high and dry in the Banswara Lok Sabha seat and the Bagidora assembly segment within it, which is slated for a simultaneous bypoll. Now everyone is fighting everyone on the same side (see *Tangle Triangle*, in *Pollhouse*, page 14, for the full sitcom). Inter alia, this scotches any potential benefits that may have accrued from a pooling of all the anti-BJP Adivasi votes. Even in its assembly election loss, the Congress had shown signs of regaining its old Adivasi loyalties and the emergence of a new tribal party was going contrary to that project.

Yet, the Congress is fighting hard. Defections aside, there are no signs of the old factionalism, with both Gehlot and Sachin Pilot loyalists being given tickets. The party hopes state chief Govind Singh Dotasra can net Jat votes while Pilot's crossover popularity helps in the Gujjar belt and beyond. Gehlot's focus, meanwhile, is on reminding the electorate of his pioneering welfare schemes while accusing the new BJP regime of winding them down. Congress leaders have also been charging the Modi regime with fostering a culture of corruption through the alleged misuse of central agencies as a tool of political coercion and the now-scrapped electoral bond scheme as a tool to strongarm corporate entities into funding the BJP.

For critics of the Congress, Dotasra has a scathing rebuke: "The BJP's manifesto is little more than hollow sloganeering, devoid of any accounting of its achievements over the past decade or a concrete plan on inflation and unemployment." It does little to dent the saffron party's confidence, though, which is convinced that the Modi magic will once again help it sail through in Rajasthan. ■